

Portfolio week 17 Digital archives reflection assignment

Part 1 (Theis)

Point 1

Jensen explains how digital archives are designed for the public rather than for the purposes of professional historians. When a person conducts a search within digital archives, this can create challenges, as these systems are designed to favor simplicity and ease of use for the general user, rather than the specificity required by historians conducting research on a particular topic.¹ Furthermore, Jensen points out that digitization is shaped by institutional priorities and available resources, meaning that not all sources are equally likely to be digitized. As a result, the digital archive reflects selective choices about what is made accessible.² This is significant for historians because researchers may mistake digitally available material for a complete historical record, even though many sources remain undigitized.

Jensen and Schriver present a similar problem and use newspapers as an example in the context of the digitization of sources. They argue that newspapers are far more extensively digitized than other types of sources, stating that “actors and topics represented in newspapers gain disproportionate visibility in the digital information landscape, while groups not represented in these materials become underrepresented.”³ This affects historians because research based mainly on digitized newspapers may reinforce dominant perspectives while overlooking marginalized groups and alternative viewpoints. Like Jensen also point out.

Point 2

Jensen argues that historians must learn how to navigate digital archives and understand how their technical design and production influence usability in order to move beyond the surface level and access the underlying material.⁴ She identifies three general aspects of digital archives that historians must consider when conducting searches: (1) predefined subject categories and tags, (2)

¹ Helle Strandgaard Jensen (2021): Digital Archival Literacy for (all) Historians, side 6

² Jensen, “Digital Archival Literacy,” side 5.

³ Astrid Ølgård Christensen Schriver og Helle Strandgaard Jensen, Arkivets digitalisering: En ny udfordring til historisk metode? (2022), Side 9

⁴ Jensen, “Digital Archival Literacy,” side 6–7

algorithms, search fields, and the sorting and display of results, and (3) metadata.⁵ This suggests that digital archives are not neutral tool, but systems that shape how historians encounter sources. Historians therefore cannot assume that search results provide a complete overview of available material and must critically reflect on how algorithms and metadata influence which sources that become available.

Part 2 (Valdemar)

i.

We have chosen an interview with a young man named Adolph Heisler, who comes from a town called Czynadowo in Czechoslovakia. The interview took place in Geneva, Switzerland, on August 27, 1946.

The metadata in the description includes topical keywords such as “World War, 1939–1945 – Personal narratives, Jewish.” These keywords make it possible to locate the material and provide an overview of what the audio recording is generally about, namely personal accounts from Jewish individuals during World War II.

In addition, the metadata contains information about geographical locations from different countries and specific places where Adolph Heisler stayed in concentration camps and labor camps. This location data can be used to find further information about these places and their significance in relation to the persecution of Jews during the war.

In the written summary of Adolph Heisler, the reader is given a brief overview of his experiences during the war, from his capture in 1939 to his liberation by American soldiers in 1945. David Boder does not ask many questions about Heisler’s life before or after the war, out of respect, as he senses that Heisler is not comfortable talking about it.

The summary takes the reader through Heisler’s time in captivity, beginning with the separation from his family, where he and his brother are sent to work in coal mines. He explains that, in his opinion, the conditions there were better than in the concentration camps, even though the work involved a great deal of hard physical labor.

⁵ Jensen, “Digital Archival Literacy,” side 6-7

It also describes how he survived the forced march out of Ohrdruf, as he was ill and therefore one of the few prisoners who were evacuated by vehicle. Shortly after this, he and many others were liberated.

ii.

As mentioned before, we have chosen the interview between Boder and Adolph Heisler. By listening to Heisler's answers rather than only reading them in transcription, the listener gains access to the emotional and human dimensions of his testimony during the interview. Todd Presner argues that when testimony is reduced to written text, important elements such as voice, rhythm, pauses, hesitations and emotional tone risk being lost. Todd illustrates this in his article "Technologies of testimony and distant witnessing. Here, he argues that the listener loses crucial sensory impressions, when you read a transcription instead of listening to the recording of the interview.⁶

This is clear in the interview with Heisler. His expressions with voice does not simply communicate about factual information about him and his memories. It also reveals how these memories affected him, and how hard it is for him to recount them. When Heisler hesitates, pauses, or changes his tone, these past moments and remembrances becomes a part of the interview itself.

Boder's voice is also important. His questions guide the interview, but his tone and pacing affect how the conversation develops. The recordings allow the listener to sense the relationship between interviewer and interviewee. Boder is not just collecting information about the given event, but he is also creating a space, which Heisler can narrate through. This supports Presner's argumentation for the I and Your relationship, which are an important aspect of understanding the character of the data.⁷

⁶ Todd Presner, Introduction, Technologies of Testimony and Distant Witnessing", u.å. side 2

⁷ Presner, Introduction", side 9.

Part 3 (Markus)

The introduction of digital humanities to historians has introduced a world of diverse digital sources, which are separated into different groups as either digitized historical sources or reborn digital sources. Digitized historical materials such as scanned manuscripts previously existed in a physical archive before being converted to the digitized world. On the other hand, reborn digitized materials are “born-digital assets” fx. websites, which have been preserved and altered through the web archive. Because of their distinct structure, historians must treat these sources differently, approaching them with critical thinking for both.’

Digitized sources

Digitized historical databases have transformed historical research and the way historians treat historical sources. The Trans Atlantic Slave Trade Database or “Voyages” for short is a prime example of this. With the translation of analog ship manifests into searchable databases, historians can now research on a whole new level by tracing historical connections between the African region and the Americas which was previously not possible.⁸

There is also a humane perspective on this. While this mechanic is great for research, it is also reducing this human tragedy into mere data points. It is therefore important to analyze these numbers with a humanistic context and be critical to historical data that may or may not be altered by the writers.⁹

Reborn digitized sources

A different methodological challenge comes with the reborn digitized sources. Instead of a ship manifest, which at first was a physical document and later digitized, the archived web lacks original texts and materials to verify against. With the web changing so quickly and

⁸ Sean M. Kelley, “DB or Not DB: Writing the History of the Slave Trade to North America in the Era of the Database”, *History Compass* 17, nr. 5 (2019): side1,2 og 5, <https://doi.org/10.1111/hic3.12530>.):

⁹ Jessica Marie Johnson, “Markup Bodies”, *Social Text* 36, nr. 4 (2018): side 4–5, <https://doi.org/10.1215/01642472-7145658>.)

rapidly, the archived website represents a unique constructed version rather than an exact replica of what once existed on the web.¹⁰

An example of a database could be the Wayback Machine. Here, Brügger discusses the Wayback Machine software developed by the Internet Archive. The way the archive works is by taking a “giant bucket” of web fragments, like HTML code or images, reassembling the fragments so that researchers can see what a webpage looked like in the past.¹¹

Reborn digitized sources also suffer from temporal and spatial inconsistency. Because the web is so everchanging, HTML codes, images, and hyperlinks are always changing and different snapshots of the same webpage can be days, weeks, and even months apart.¹²

Schrivner and Jensen’ article

“En ny udfordring til historisk metode?” is an article by Astrid Ølgaard Christensen Schrivner and Helle Strandgaard Jensen, which argues that the digitization of cultural heritage archives is a methodological challenge for historians. While historians increasingly rely on digital archives, they rarely think about how the digital infrastructure itself shapes their research. The article critiques the traditional Danish historiographical perspective, which historically have treated archives as neutral repositories. The article instead tries to argue that digital archives act as active co-producers of history. To illustrate this, Schrivner and Jensen have analyzed the Royal Danish Library’s digital aerial photography archive, “Danmark set fra luften”, and have established several ways the digital platform has altered historical reality. Selection and institutional bias, technical invisibility, metadata flaws, and loss of context and precision are among the main factors. They conclude that historians therefore must develop digital competencies to critically evaluate digital archives.¹³

¹⁰ “Bru%CC%88gger%202019”, side 22.

¹¹ “Bru%CC%88gger%202019”, u.å., side 23.

¹² Bru%CC%88gger%202019”, side 22–24

¹³ Schrivner and Jensen, En ny udfordring til historisk metode?, n.d., side 1, 6, 24.

